



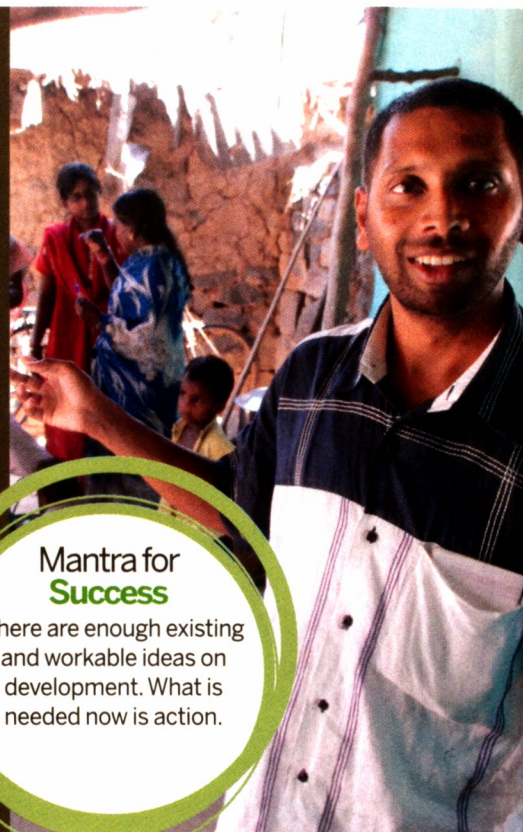
“WHAT WE LACK AT ALL LEVELS IS CLEAR leadership which makes sure that the benefits of democracy reach the common man.”

G. SENTHILKUMAR, SOCIAL WORKER, 34

The whole of Thennur, a small village near Trichy, calls him *Enga Ooru Shivaji* (Shivaji of the village), after the megahit superstar Rajinikanth starrer *Shivaji-The Boss*. In the movie Rajinikanth plays a reformist who returns to India after earning a fortune in the US. Similarly, Senthilkumar, who worked as a software engineer in Detroit, US, at a salary of Rs 4 lakh per month till four years ago, came back to Tamil Nadu to do social service. Thanks to him, Thennur today has an eight-bed hospital, a school and a computer centre.

Senthilkumar has formed a trust called Payir (literally meaning crop),

which seeks to remove communal differences between people. To achieve this, he believes, it is essential to equip villagers economically and fulfil their basic needs—healthcare, education, employment and bridging the IT divide. Now he aspires to kick-start such reforms at the national level. “I want to get involved in the development of village communities all over India, especially in the North-east,” he says. While he invested Rs 30 lakh himself, his friends have been contributing to Payir. Till now he has spent Rs 40 lakh and continues to mobilise funds for expansion of his activities. **by Mahalingam Ponnusamy**



Mantra for Success

There are enough existing and workable ideas on development. What is needed now is action.

HK RAJASHEKAR

“MONEY IS IMPORTANT BUT WHAT’S THE POINT OF education if you can’t help society? That’s the challenge.”

JAYARAM VENKATESAN

SOCIAL WORKER, 27

Like many others, Jayaram Venkatesan, a postgraduate student in electrical engineering at the University of Cincinnati in Ohio, loved watching TV and surfing the Net. The images of the devastating tsunami back home in Tamil Nadu in December 2004 were anything but pleasant, but they changed his life forever. “It was a turning point. I contemplated returning to my country and taking up full-time social work,” he says.

After completing his research on predictive modelling and analysis of posture time series, Venkatesan returned to Chennai in 2007 to work with Standard Chartered’s wealth management wing. But his passion to provide models of livelihood for the disadvantaged segments of society won over and within a year, he moved to AID

India as a project manager.

Flush with new ideas, today, Venkatesan has several projects in hand. His sustainable and scalable livelihood models for the disadvantaged have helped create jobs for thousands of villagers in the Kanchipuram district. He has pioneered a study on financial inclusion with the Reserve Bank of India’s College of Agricultural Banking to analyse the cost and usage of no-frills bank accounts in Cuddalore district. Making toys from waste wood, he is working to produce materials for anganwadis. He is also collaborating with the Institute for Financial Management and Research on a microfinance project for the poor.

But can he beat the system? “Politicians are not a hopeless lot,” he says, “it’s the money power that corrupts. The need of the hour is political and electoral reforms.” **by Mahalingam Ponnusamy**

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If you strongly believe in something, keep hitting at it with patience. Success will surely come one day.



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